part of the work that she was to take up under the Nehru Fellowship granted to her and she was already building up her academic framework for it. Very naturally, therefore, she was very keen to avail of this opportunity. The Department of Home Affairs (Government of Delhi), however, did not quite view it in this same way and a denial was very much on the cards. Kiran, therefore, sought an appointment with Rajesh Pilot, minister of state for home affairs, Government of India. The same day and the same time that she was with Rajesh Pilot, she had an appointment with the chief minister of Delhi, Madan Lal Khurana, a meeting she herself had solicited. The meeting with Rajesh Pilot, however, got extended and she was left with no option but to tender her regrets to the CM's office. Kiran clarified that she went to see Rajesh Pilot so as to bring to his notice how rare and valuable invitations were made to fall by the wayside because of inadequate interest taken by the bureaucracy. Rajesh Pilot effectively intervened and directed the file to be sent up to S. B. Chavan (the Union home minister) for further orders. Till then it had not gone to him. Chavan, on Kiran's file, approved both the pending invitations – one for the UN Summit and the other for British prisons. The approval of the Central Government came as a shock to Kiran herself! But for bureaucrats in the Delhi Government this approval became a cause for revenge against Kiran! They managed to turn the CM against her by convincing him that there was an obvious effort to affront him. This apparently convinced the CM and he went public with his resentment by stating that 'if that is how she feels why does she want to work for the Delhi State Government?'

During her absence from Tihar the Bharatiya Kisan Union leader, Mahendra Singh Tikait (who had a huge following of farmers), was sent as a political prisoner there for a few days. Harsharan Singh Balli, the Delhi minister for industries and prison, requested the jail staff to permit Tikait to smoke his *hookah* (a kind of pipe) in prison and thereby allow the tobacco required for it. As mentioned earlier in this book, one of the biggest challenges that Kiran and her jail staff had faced in Tihar was the imposition of the ban on smoking and on all tobacco products. They were certainly not going to allow all that effort to come to nought merely for appeasing the whims of any one individual. The request, therefore, was quite naturally turned down by the DIG (Prisons) Jaydev Sarangi.

This refusal of a 'simple request' quite peeved the concerned minister, so much so that he declared to the media that where his friend was being denied the 'humble *hookah*', her 'friend' Charles Sobhraj was being permitted foreign pipes and foreign tobacco. This charge, of course, was made out of sheer churlishness and was utterly baseless because Sobhraj was known to be a non-smoker. In another book on Tihar, written in the early 1990s, Kumkum Chaddha, of *The Hindustan Times*, had also mentioned the fact that Sobhraj abstained from tobacco. As a matter of fact, one of the Sikh prisoners was quite irked about the minister (who was also a Sikh) insisting on permitting the *hookah* for Tikait and declared that why did he not insist on a *hookah* in the gurdwara? This faux pas was meant to be covered up by another claim that Sobhraj was permitted the use of a typewriter that went against the Delhi Jail Manual. Wilson John, again of *The Hindustan Times*, even quoted the relevant section from the Jail Manual that stipulated that a typewriter was amongst one of the items that were treated as prohibited property. However, he stopped short in his quote of the rider that stated that the abovelisted items (in the section) were prohibited only till such time as they were not provided to the prisoners with the *permission of the jail superintendent*. As a matter of fact, typewriting was one of the functional skills that was taught to the inmates of Tihar and typewriters were provided freely to them. Here is the relevant excerpt from the Jail Manual:

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